historians, in sorting out the various rituals and beliefs of Akbar, have tried to determine influences and filiation – whether Zoroastrian, Sufi, Nath Yogi, or Brahmanical . . . A general tendency has been to treat the "Divine Faith" as a bizarre concoction of Akbar's fertile intellect.' Richards, however, following the work of S.A.A. Rizvi, argues that Akbar did not seek to invent a religion, but rather a system of discipleship to himself – or, in the words of Munis Faruqui, a 'religiously eclectic imperial cult', a *silsilah-i muridan*, 'circle of disciples', rather than a din-i-ilahi, divine faith.[55]

'In Rizvi's view,' writes Richards, 'discipleship represented a major effort to create an exceptionally loyal and reliable cadre of nobles' – a clever and necessary invention, and a logical extension of the mansabdari system, by which Akbar's disparate nobility, Khurasani to Khatri, might overcome their many differences to share a 'solemn commitment to an Emperor who had reached the highest degree of purity, knowledge and ontological status possible for a mortal'.

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So, in 1582, Akbar was unchallenged, and began to become unchallengeable, a god to his people, a glue to bind his amirs. And yet, it was in this year of unleashed possibility that Akbar began, also, to confront the pitfalls of middle age.

In October 1582, days before his first solar weighing and fortieth birthday, Akbar caught a stomach bug. At first, the emperor left it to God to heal him. When, eventually, he let some doctors in, they argued endlessly over treatments – the prescription of laxatives being a sticking point between followers of Greek and Indian medicine. Abul Fazl 'much upset . . . got into the fray', chivvying them along to make up their minds. 'How can such inappropriate argument help a delicate patient?'[56] It was over a month before the emperor was fully cured. The public 'rejoiced' – and yet, the prolonged illness strikes a faint note of foreboding in an otherwise rousing symphony.

. Abu'l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 3, trans. Henry Beveridge (First published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

. Some Qaqshals never gave in. Amongst them was Dastam Qaqshal, who was killed in 1585, and is worth a mention for his endearingly named elephant Son Kaduh, Golden Pumpkin, now taken into the imperial stables.